

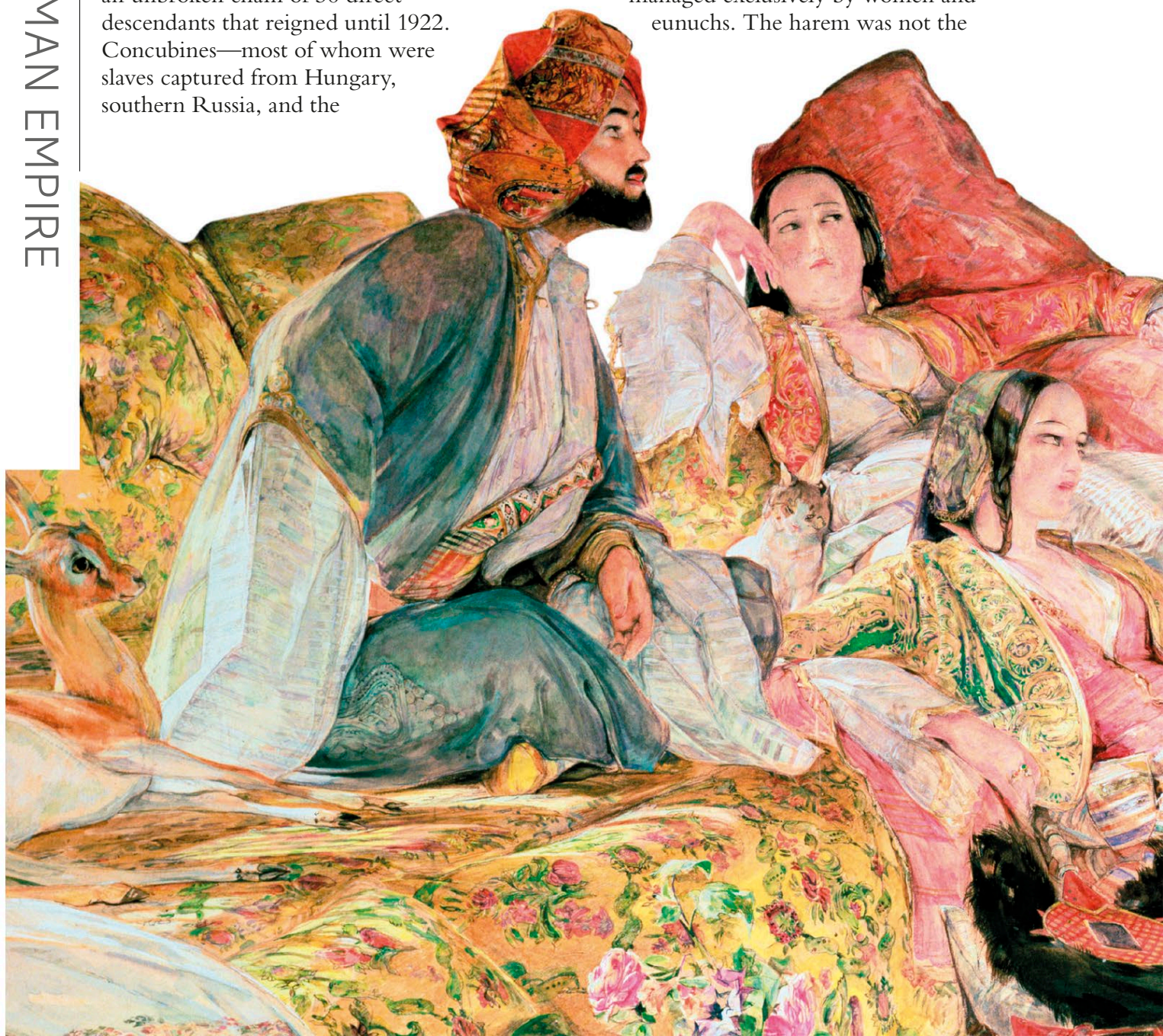
THE SULTANATE of women

THE OTTOMAN EMPIRE

Women were influential in imperial Ottoman life. The mighty Ottoman Empire, founded in 1299 as a small principality in modern-day Turkey, endured for over 600 years, peaking in the 16th and 17th centuries, when it controlled most of the Middle East, North Africa, and Eastern Europe. The founder of the empire, Osman I, was succeeded by an unbroken chain of 36 direct descendants that reigned until 1922. Concubines—most of whom were slaves captured from Hungary, southern Russia, and the

Caucasus, as well as Africa and the Middle East—were central to this dynastic stability. Sons born to the sultan's concubines were regarded as legitimate and could succeed him.

The sultan's concubines, along with his wives and female relatives, lived in the imperial harem (women's quarters), secluded from the rest of his court. It was staffed and managed exclusively by women and eunuchs. The harem was not the



► Western fantasy

The idea of the harem fueled the imaginations of Western artists, as in this stereotypical painting (c.1850) by British artist John Frederick Lewis.